

the alphabet tree



Leo Lionni

the alphabet tree

by Leo Lionni

An Alphabet Tree?

Yes, the tree where letters cling to leaves
and to each other to spell words and form
sentences for the word-bug.

A Word-Bug?!

Naturally, and they do it for the purple
caterpillar, too. Who else could give them
better advice on how to stick together and
make sense?

A Purple Caterpillar?!!

Why, yes, since he is particularly
concerned with meanings and important
things to say. Important to him, to you, to
the world, and to Leo.

Leo? Leo Who?!!!

Leo Lionni, of course. Haven't you ever
heard of him?!!!!*

* If you haven't turn to the back flap of
this jacket.



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Leo Lionni

Alfred A. Knopf  New York



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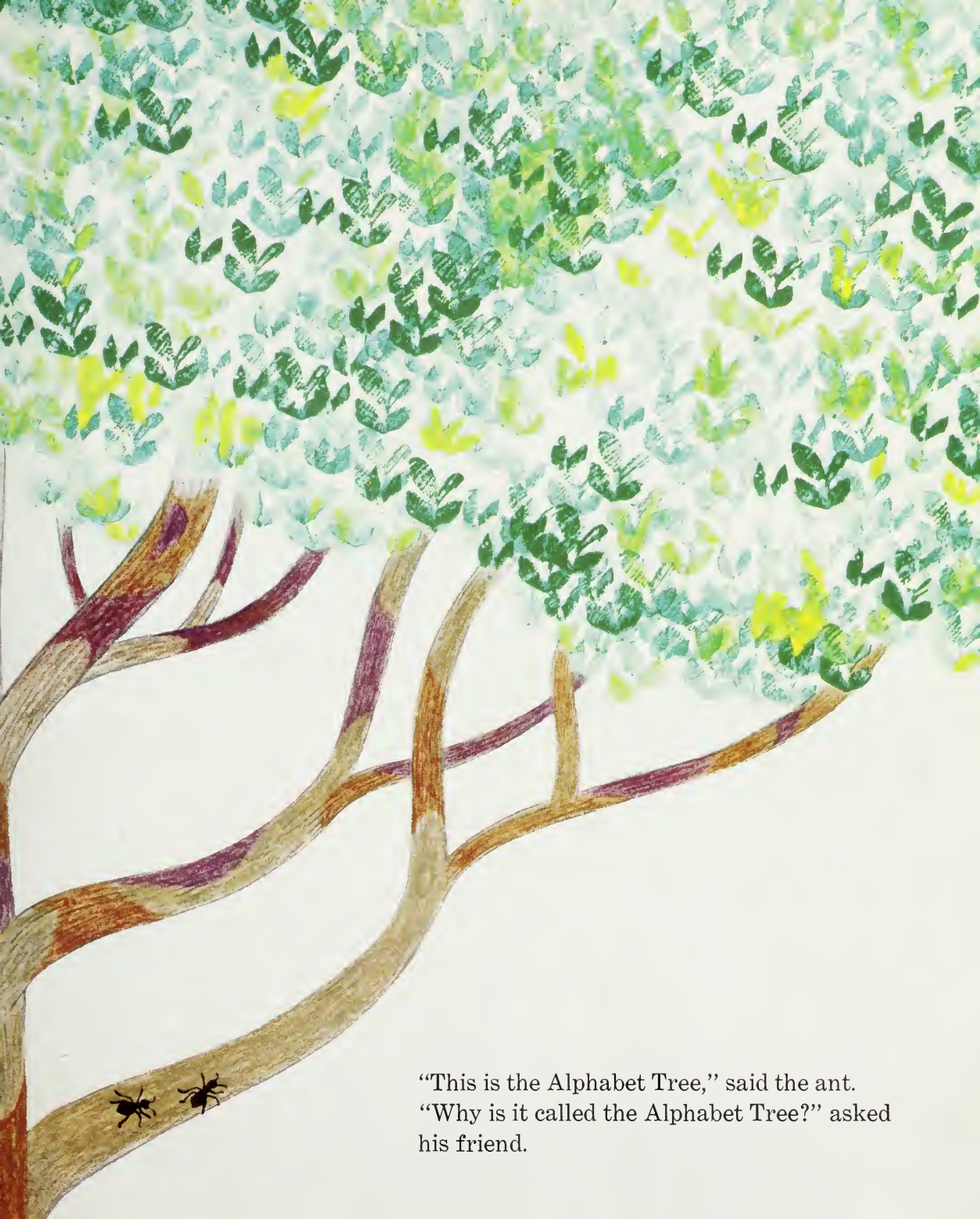
SUMMARY: After a storm blows some of them away, the letters on the alphabet tree learn from a strange bug to be stronger by forming words.

Then a caterpillar comes along and tells them that words are not enough; they must say something important.

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“This is the Alphabet Tree,” said the ant.
“Why is it called the Alphabet Tree?” asked
his friend.



“Because not so long ago this tree was full of letters. They lived a happy life, hopping from leaf to leaf on the highest twigs.



Each letter had its favorite leaf, where it would sit in the sun and rock in the gentle breeze of spring.







One day the breeze became a strong gust and the gust became a gale.



g

s

x

x

p

j

o

e

d

a

The letters clung to the leaves with all their might—but some were blown away, and the others were very frightened.



u

ε

r

q

q

n

i

n

z

c

o

s

z



nvno
rau
yogr
syzhs
atnzhs
pceogla
simysbst
enbfcmw
aiuyc
axqhs



When the storm had passed they
huddled together in fear, deep in
the foliage of the lower branches.



A funny bug, red and black with
bright yellow wings, saw them there,
hiding in the shade.

'We are hiding from the wind,'
the letters explained. 'But who are you?'

'I am the word-bug,' the bug answered.

'I can teach you to make words.

If you get together in threes and fours,
and even more,

no wind will be strong enough
to blow you away.'

nvno
rau
your
sybr
atnzis
pceogla
simysbta
nhfchw
druyc
adqha





z

cat

y

bug

leaf

tree

s

d

me

o

i

e

c

u

p

Patiently he taught the letters to join together and make words.





cat

leaf

red

bug

tree

you

zoo

we

small

earth

big

peace

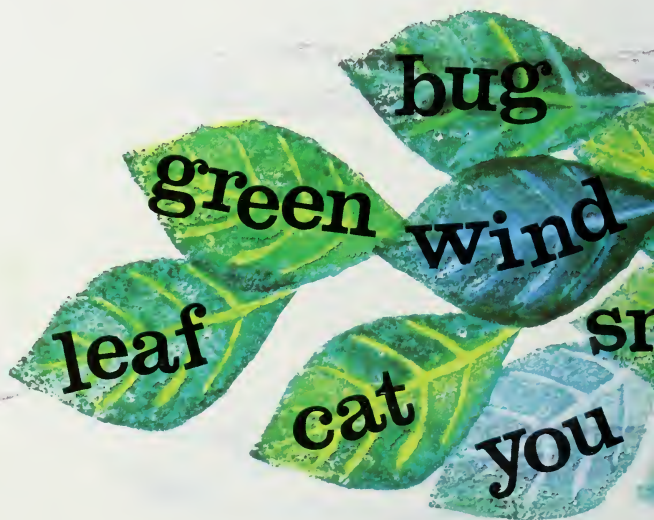
now



Some made short and easy words like *dog* and *cat*,
others learned to make more difficult ones: *twig*,
leaf, and even *earth*.



Happily they climbed back onto the highest leaves, and when the wind came they held on without fear. The word-bug had been right.





peace

on

good

tree

men

and

red

will

earth

Then, one summer morning, a strange caterpillar appeared amid the foliage. He was purple, woolly, and very large. 'Such confusion!' said the caterpillar when he saw the words scattered around the leaves. 'Why don't you get together and make sentences—and *mean* something?'





The letters had never thought of this. Now they could really write—*say* things. They said things about the wind, the leaves, the bug. ‘Good!’ said the caterpillar approvingly. ‘But not good enough.’



‘Why?’ asked the letters, surprised.
‘Because you must say something *important*,’
said the caterpillar.

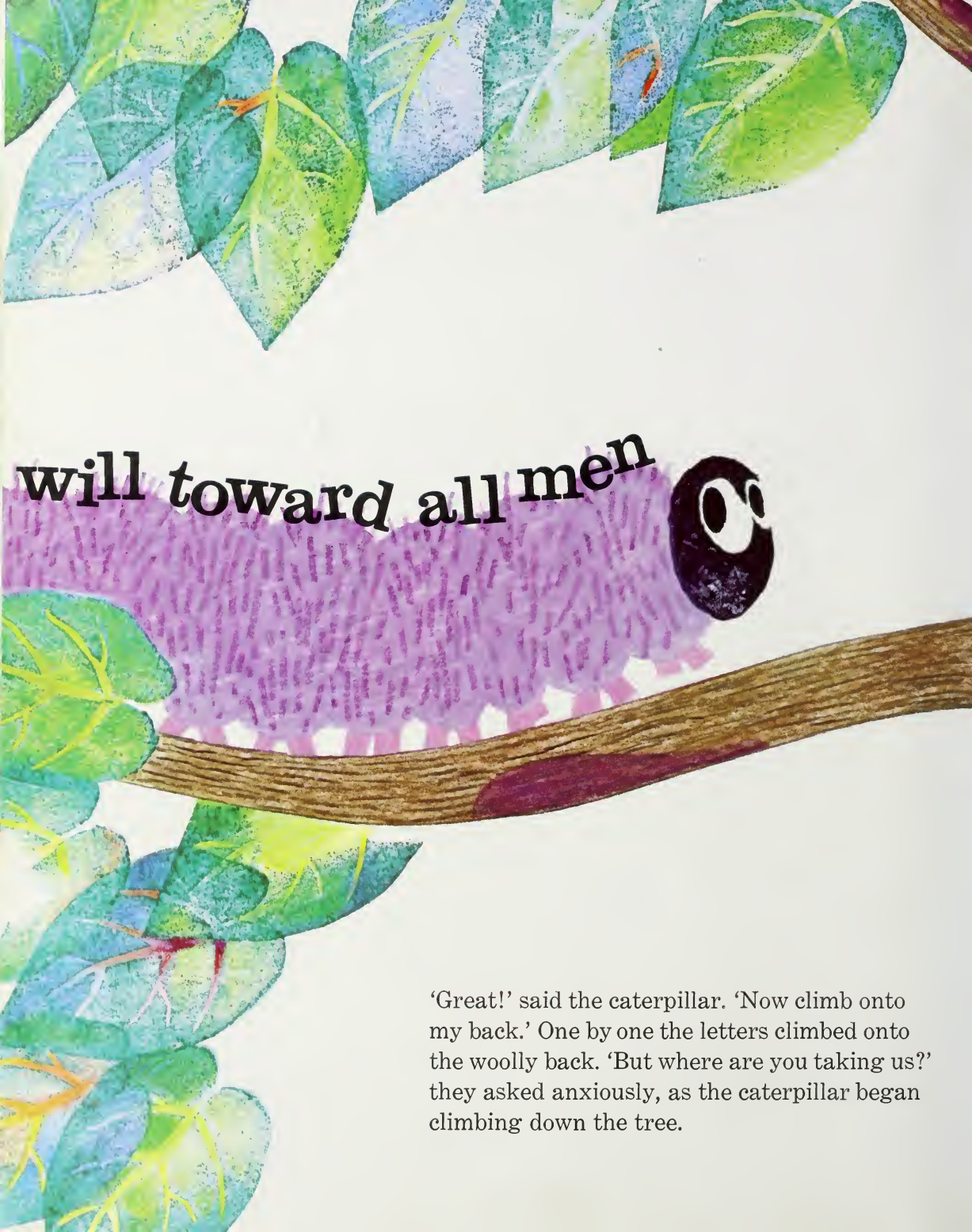




peace on earth and

The letters tried to think of something important, *really* important. Finally they knew what to say. What could be more important than peace? PEACE ON EARTH AND GOODWILL TOWARD ALL MEN, they spelled excitedly.



The illustration shows a caterpillar with a purple, woolly body and a black head with two large white eyes. It is crawling on a brown tree branch. The background is filled with various green and blue leaves, some with yellow and red veins. The text "will toward all men" is written in a bold, black, sans-serif font, slanted upwards from left to right, positioned above the caterpillar's body.

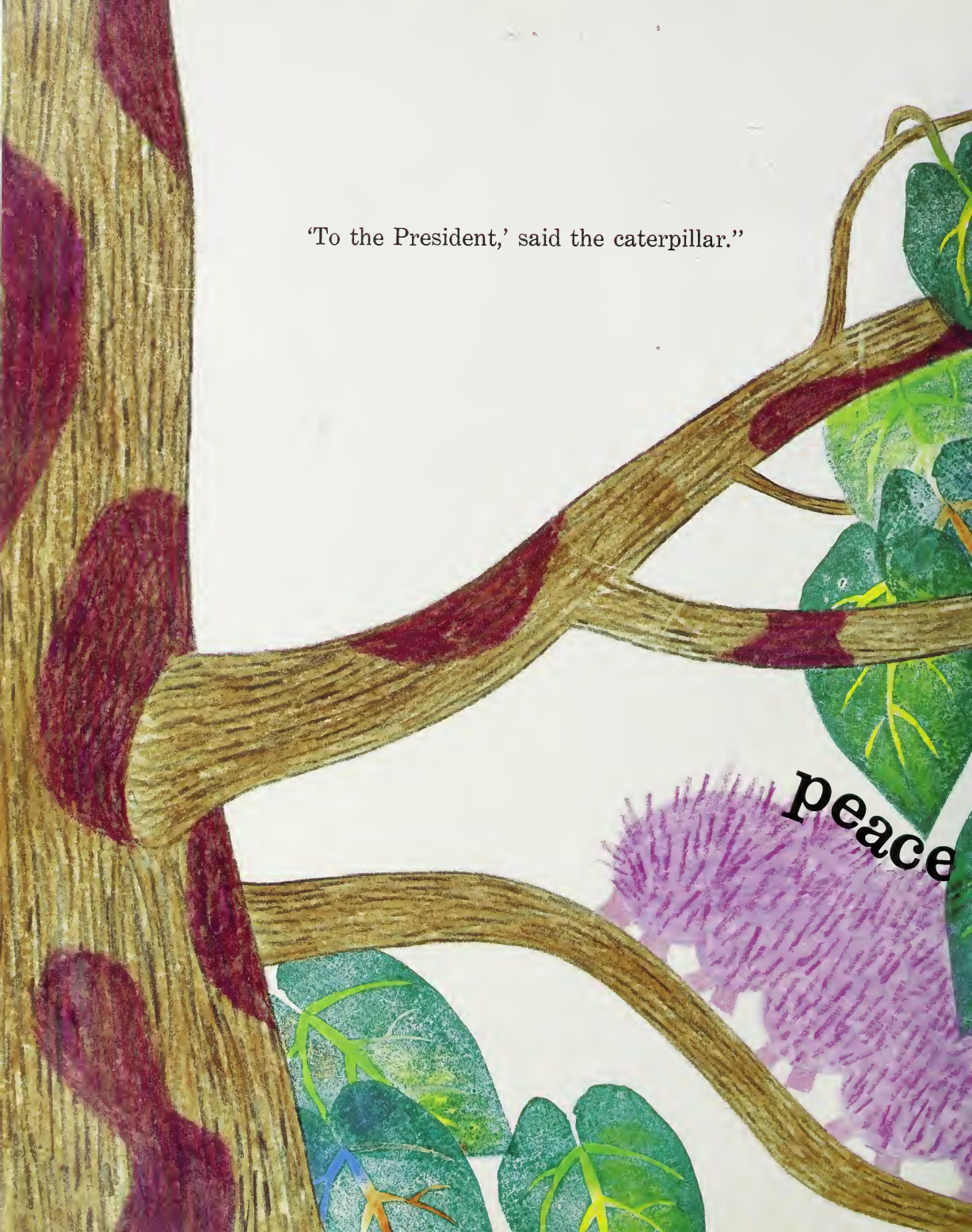
will toward all men

‘Great!’ said the caterpillar. ‘Now climb onto my back.’ One by one the letters climbed onto the woolly back. ‘But where are you taking us?’ they asked anxiously, as the caterpillar began climbing down the tree.



'To the President,' said the caterpillar."

peace









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